

About the Blurring of Work and Play: Organizational Dynamics Emerging in a First-Person Shooter Videogame

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ABSTRACT

The aim of this study is to investigate the organizational dynamics occurring in a multiplayer video game. The research involves E-sports professionals, streamers, and amateur players, who have different motives for playing and represent different “work-play” conditions, and explores how they differently enact organizational behaviors in the game. An ethnographic study within an Italian gaming community is currently in progress. I focus on “Call of Duty: Warzone”, a First-Person Shooter Battle Royale game which requires players to enact organizational efforts in order to reach the in-game objectives (e.g., defeat the enemy team). The study uses i) semi-structured interviews with amateur players and participant observation conducted in the game environment played by the amateurs, ii-iii) observation of gaming sessions, analysis of online content and semi-structured interviews with reference to streamers and professionals, iv) analysis of communication exchanges of all three types of players during the gaming sessions. I expect that players belonging to different categories will enact distinct organizational behaviors and give rise to various organizational structures. A cross-comparison between them, which is missing in current literature, would clarify how different modalities of combining work and play impact on organizational behaviors and dynamics.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human-centered computing; • Human-centered interaction (HCI); • Empirical studies in HCI;

KEYWORDS

Video games, First-Person Shooter, E-sports, Streaming, Organizational Behavior

ACM Reference Format:

Arianna Boldi. 2022. About the Blurring of Work and Play: Organizational Dynamics Emerging in a First-Person Shooter Videogame. In *Companion Computer Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing (CSCW'22 Companion)*, November 08–22, 2022, Virtual Event, Taiwan. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 4 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3500868.3561398>

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CSCW'22 Companion, November 08–22, 2022, Virtual Event, Taiwan

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ACM ISBN 978-1-4503-9190-0/22/11.

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3500868.3561398>

1 RESEARCH QUESTIONS

In recent years, the Western world has undergone a series of transformations that impacted the world of work and the way it is organized. As a consequence, new social and organizational structures, such as virtual organizations, appeared [11]. Research identified not only opportunities in these novel organizational forms, but also a series of potential threats [16]: for instance, with the displacement of the workforce, how to supervise or enable knowledge sharing among the members of a certain organization emerged as relevant issues [10]. According to a growing tradition of academic literature, possible solutions to these concerns could be drawn from the analysis of digital gaming worlds [18, 26, 28].

Video games, and Massive Multiplayer Online Games (MMOG) in particular, are responsible for a large portion of the experiences that people have of virtual worlds [37]. With an estimated 1 billion online gamers worldwide [8] they represent a consistent part of human experience. MMOGs often allow players to complete demanding tasks by encouraging the formation of organizational structures that deeply engage them in organizational dynamics [28]. In this sense, video games, and specifically MMOGs, represent an optimal environment where to observe complex organizational behaviors, allowing for the understanding of how organizational dynamics unfold in virtual contexts and how design may effectively support them.

In fact, despite games are separated from the mundane by definition [6, 15], the idea that ludic environments might actually be intertwined with “serious” contexts has taken hold in the last years. Not only video games are often designed to mirror already existing social structures, such as work ecosystems [21], but the whole idea that “play” and “labour” are antagonistic figures has been challenged recently [13, 35].

Practical examples that testify the blurring of work and play dimensions are offered by a diversified collection of studies, concluding that people do not only populate virtual worlds for the sake of fun, but for more complex reasons and to fulfill a wide range of needs [2]. Players expect video games to convey complex - and not necessarily positive emotional experiences [3], and gamers may be interested in maximizing progress towards in-game objectives [34] even performing repetitive and boring actions [12]. However, this may lead amateur players, who are players that in principle play “only for fun”, to perceive playing as a commitment, an obligation, or even a work [39]. The “seriousness” of play, and its “contamination” with work practices, is also evident if we consider the emergence of professional figures in the gaming environment, like E-sports players and streamers. These gamers get a profit from the activity, such as money or social status, whose value is recognized in the “real world”. As a matter of fact, E-sports professionals are labourers who must develop their skills to pursue a remunerated career in the

area [35], while streamers do an “emotional labour” which is meant to attract an audience of spectators [17], some of whom support them financially [38]. In this sense, these three types of players are interesting for the fact that they differently intertwine “playing” and “working” practices during the gaming activity.

Amateur players, streamers, and professionals might address the game with a different mindset, depending on their role, goals, and the perception of their activity as a more or less “professional”. This research starts from the hypothesis that the different “work-play” conditions characterizing these three kinds of players differently impact on their in-game organizational behaviors, namely how they collaborate, compete, communicate, and negotiate in the game. Grounding on these assumptions, I intend to investigate the organizational dynamics characterizing these three categories of gamers in a Multiplayer Online video game. Specifically, I intend to answer to the following research questions: *How do different kinds of players organize the game action, depending on their perception of the gaming activity? How does the design of the game affect the organizational practices of different categories of players?* In addition to that, I would explore a series of sub-questions, which relate to specific organizational processes such as communication, learning, the management of power and possible enactment of dark organizational practices. Differently from previous research, which focused either on amateurs, or streamers or professionals individually, I would attempt to include these three categories within the same study trying to explore similarities and differences in their in-game organizational behaviors, as well as their reciprocal interactions (e.g., team composed by streamers and amateur players or streamers and professionals). The findings of this study might be useful not only to shed light on the complex ecosystem characterizing the contemporary gaming organizational practices, by taking into account the organizational behaviors of different kinds of players and their interactions, but also to potentially better understand “serious” organizational behaviors, like those enacted in virtual organizations, where working practices can be combined with game-like activities (e.g., through gamification practices [28]).

2 WORK IN PROGRESS

To address the research questions described above, in the last year I have been ethnographically investigating the digital gaming environment of “*Call of Duty: Warzone*” (or simply “Warzone”) and its Italian community. The reason underlying the choice of a qualitative methodology is the willingness to capture the different takes on the game of different categories of players, as well as to investigate their organizational practices “in the wild”. An ethnography might help the researcher better explore people’s subjective meanings and investigate different perspectives from their standpoint [14].

Warzone is a Multiplayer Online Battle Royale game developed for several gaming platforms and published in 2020 by Activision as a free-to-play game. Whether they are alone or in groups, players’ overall objective is to survive until the end, by killing all the enemy players in the arena while a mortal gas cloud shrinks the playable area as time goes by. Despite being a First-Person Shooter, where rapid action and individual skills are crucial, the game entails interesting organizational dynamics because players face enemies organized in teams, in a particularly stressful environment, whose

mistakes are punished by defeat and the end of the game. In addition to this, Warzone is a popular game and for this reason it has caught the eye of an audience hungry for web-generated content. Therefore, in the past two years, streamer channels devoted entirely to the game, tournaments, and sports organizations around the game have sprung up.

Building on previous digital reflexive ethnographies (e.g., [25, 29, 31]), my ethnography adopts a reflexive approach, which values the researcher’s subjective experience and considers it worthy to be explored [36], thus also including an auto-ethnographic work [27, 30] ensuring more transparency to the investigation [7, 24, 32]. The ethnographic work has been conducted since May 2021. Within this period, phases of participant observation and data analysis were alternated. First, I played the game as a participant observer and, as I learned the basics, I began to participate to the online spaces of the community, such as Facebook and Telegram private groups of the game, content communities, i.e., Instagram, Youtube and Twitch channels, and official websites containing walkthroughs and guides of Warzone. After two months from the beginning of the ethnography, I joined a *regiment*, a sort of clan system, which aggregates people who want to share the game experience in a continuative way, counting about 128 members. In this way I could join and observe matches with different players, take notes of their social dynamics and their daily informal discussions.

In my analysis I have been using different data sources. I have been collecting materials in the form of documents, videos, personal experiences, gaming sessions, informal conversations. Generally speaking, observations are conducted in a participant way on amateur players, while streamers/professional are observed through their social media channels, which are open to the public. Some of these observations and gaming sessions are recorded, having the consent of players. Interviews are conducted on all the three types of players and recorded to allow for their transcription and subsequent data analysis.

The next steps for completing the work include the gathering of additional data and their analysis. As for the data, I plan to conduct further observations of all the matches that I will participate in and record a number of them. Personal experiences will be collected through a daily diary that I have started to write since the beginning of the ethnography and that contains observations and reflections concerning the game sessions and informal conversation. So far, I have conducted 20 interviews addressed to amateur players, but I plan to conduct an equal number of interviews to both professionals and streamers. A separate discussion is reserved to the collection of social media content. Facebook groups such as *Call of Duty Warzone ITA* and *Call of Duty Italia* are scanned every day, as they testify the Warzone culture. Public and private groups have been joined to stay updated on the game. Through the exploration of Facebook pages, as well as of Twitter, Instagram, and Twitch accounts I hope to grasp how these players interact with their followers, the main topics of discussion and so on. So far, I have been following several streamers and selected a group of 12 individuals who are the most followed by the community. I plan to devote more attention to the observation of their live sessions and their content uploaded on Youtube. The same will occur for professional tournaments, that will be observed to better understand how organizational behavior occurs during official events.

I will analyze these data by following two main approaches. The field notes, the informal conversations and the interviews will be analyzed through a thematic analysis [5, 33], adopting an inductive stance [23] for the whole process. The analysis will be mostly conducted by applying open and axial coding techniques [9]. In addition to that, I will employ a “participant researchers” strategy [20], asking the informants to give feedback on the line of argument which will be emerging from the analysis. Secondly, I plan to analyze the communication exchanges occurring in the game within the methodological framework of conversational analysis: to do so, I will ground on previous benchmark studies which analyzed conversations within video games to understand the underlying gaming practices [1, 19, 22]. Finally, I will try to figure out whether organizational theories that are used to understand “serious” organizational behaviors may be usefully employed to interpret in-game behaviors in order to gain further insights from the collected data.

3 EXPECTED CONTRIBUTION

Initial observations conducted in the game show a difference in the way players cope with the in-game difficulties and, in particular, with the diffusion of unethical behaviors like cheating, i.e., the attempt to gain an unfair advantage over the other players [4]. So far, the investigation has shown that players differently enact an intense sense-making activity about cheating and are differently impacted by how the game (and the cheats) are designed depending on the category to which they belong (i.e., amateurs, streamers, professionals).

Different kinds of players have different interpretations of what it means “to cheat” in Warzone and tend to condemn illicit behaviors (e.g., formally report players) more or less depending on whether monetary or social gains result from using cheats. In addition, different players have different degrees of knowledge about the game, and this factor may influence the correctness of their judgments. This is relevant, as frequently accusing people of being cheaters (*hackusations*) leads players to have the feeling that the cheaters are everywhere and the gaming environment is unsafe and toxic. However, while amateur players do not have the ability to spot unfair players, streamers and professionals have the power to drive the beliefs of the game community, having their behavior a major impact on the evolution of the phenomenon: being the reference point of a large number of amateur players, some of them take on the role of “policemen”, keeping watch over the community, spotting the “bad apples” and publicly condemn them. As a result, in Warzone a culture of surveillance and paranoia is currently spreading.

These preliminary results already show strong trends of differentiation among the types of players identified and strengthen the initial assumption of the study, namely that players belonging to different categories that differently combine “work-play conditions” enact distinct behaviors and give rise to diverse organizational dynamics. In this sense, this work may contribute to research investigating organizational dynamics in virtual contexts, both in the field of Organizational Psychology and Computer-Supported Cooperative Work (CSCW). In particular, my contribution to CSCW builds on social computing research on organizational dynamics in

virtual environments and aims to expand our understanding of organizational practices in video games. The research will allow us to better understand whether and how organizational dynamics (e.g., cooperation, hierarchies, etc.) change depending on the role that people play in their community (e.g., if they have a fandom, if they stream their live sessions) and their motivation for playing (e.g., serious, fun or a combination of the two). Moreover, we could draw insights on what organizational strategies people adopt to collaborate from a distance in a highly competitive environment, and how certain design patterns may differently support different categories of individuals depending on their role and their motivation to play. Finally, taking into account such roles and how they interact with each other (e.g., when streamers play with their followers) will widen our perspective on organizational phenomena like cheating and exertion of power, which could potentially mirror dynamics that also occur in working contexts. All these findings could then be possibly applied even to “serious” organizational domains, like virtual organizations.

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